Nebraska Football Win History (1890-2025)

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Section 1. Introduction

This project looks at Nebraska football from 1890 to 2025. Nebraska used to be one of the best teams in the country, but it has struggled lately. I wanted to see when things changed. I made six goals and did all of the charts in Excel.

I used Excel instead of Tableau, so nothing is on Tableau Public. All the charts are in Section 6, and the workbook link is in Section 5.

Section 2. Data Description

- **Domain:** College football. Each row is one Nebraska season.
- **Data file:** A table of every season with the year, coach, conference, record, bowl game, and final rankings. The original table had 137 rows and 9 columns.
- **Rows and columns used:** 136 rows and 25 columns.
- **Source:** Wikipedia - List of Nebraska Cornhuskers football seasons. The numbers come from Nebraska's official football record book.

Section 3. Data Cleaning Strategies

1. Took out 2026 because the season isn't over yet.
2. Split records like "9-2-1" into Wins, Losses, and Ties columns.
3. Added a win percentage column (ties count as half a win).
4. Cleaned up rankings and bowl names so they only had numbers and names.
5. Added Decade and Conference Era columns for grouping.
6. Checked that the total wins and losses matched the source.

Section 4. Clean Dataset

The clean data has 136 rows and 25 columns. Here are a few rows and some of the main columns:

Season	Head coach	Conf.	W	L	T	Win %	Conf %	Bowl	Result	AP
1971	Bob Devaney	Big Eight	13	0	0	1.000	1.000	Orange	W	1
1995	Tom Osborne	Big Eight	12	0	0	1.000	1.000	Fiesta	W	1
2012	Bo Pelini	Big Ten	10	4	0	0.714	0.875	Capital One	L	25
2025	Matt Rhule	Big Ten	7	6	0	0.538	0.444	Las Vegas	L	

Section 5. Visualization Tools

I used Excel because the data was small and I already know how to use it. I made a summary table for each goal with SUMIF and COUNTIF, then made the charts from those tables.

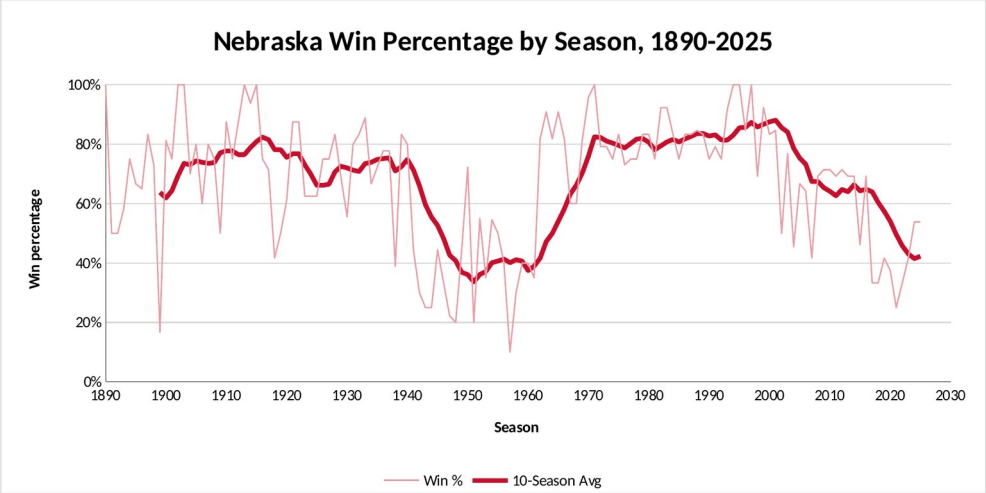
Links: Excel workbook | GitHub repository

Section 6. Visualizations and Stories

6.1 Goal 1: Win % Over Time

Goal: Show how Nebraska's win percentage has changed from 1890 to 2025.

Chart: Line chart with a 10-season moving average (Excel).

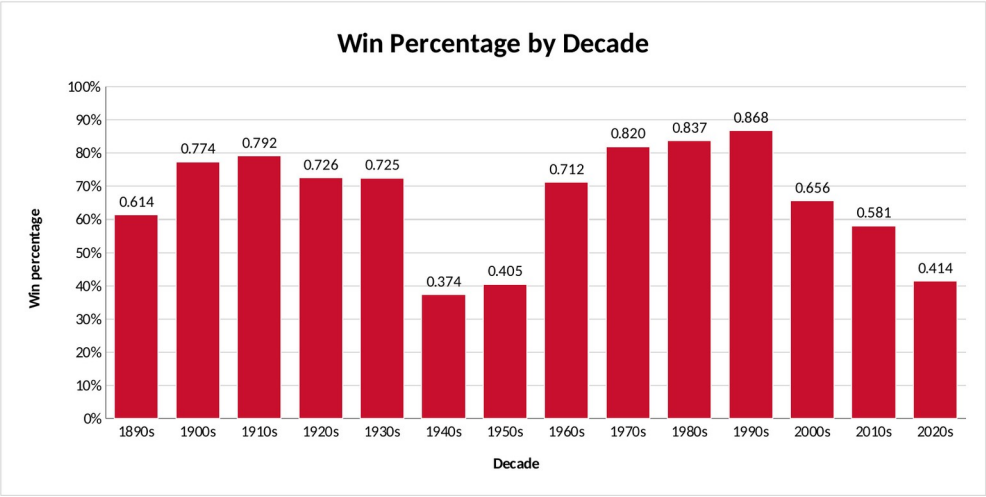


Story: Nebraska won a lot early on, then hit its low point in the 1940s and 50s. After Bob Devaney was hired in 1962 the line went way up and peaked from 1992-2001 (.881). It has gone down since then, and the last 10 years (.423) are the worst since 1962.

6.2 Goal 2: Win % by Decade

Goal: Compare win percentage by decade to find the best and worst decades.

Chart: Column chart with data labels (Excel).

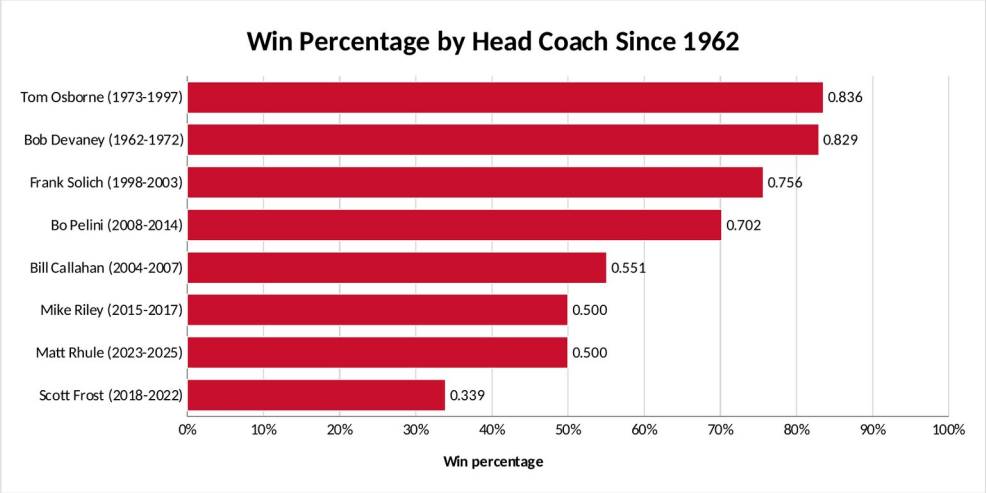


Story: The 1990s were the best decade (.868) and the 1940s were the worst (.374). Every decade since the 1990s has been worse than the one before it.

6.3 Goal 3: Head Coaches Since 1962

Goal: Compare the win percentage of every head coach since 1962.

Chart: Bar chart sorted from highest to lowest (Excel).

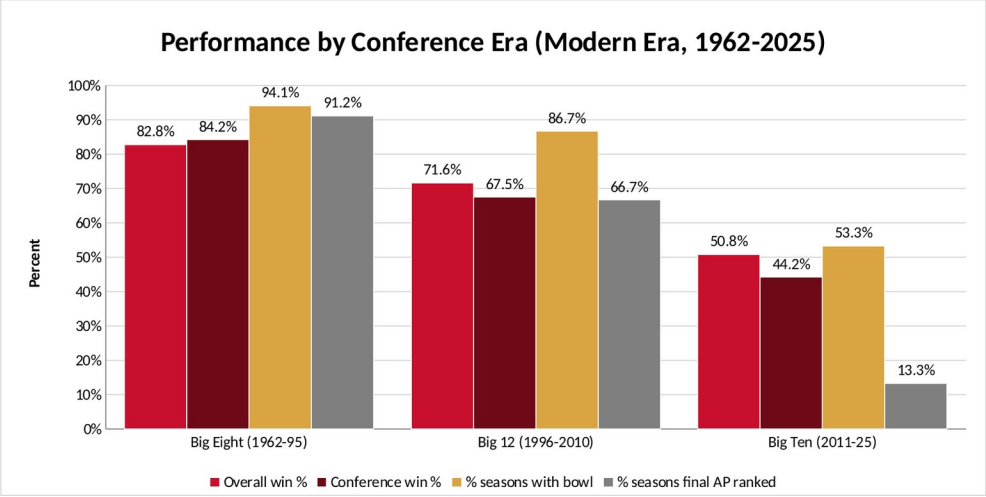


Story: Osborne (.836) and Devaney (.829) are way ahead of everyone else. Every coach since 2015 is at .500 or below, and Scott Frost (.339) is last.

6.4 Goal 4: Conference Eras

Goal: Compare Nebraska's results in the Big Eight, Big 12, and Big Ten.

Chart: Clustered column chart with four measures (Excel).

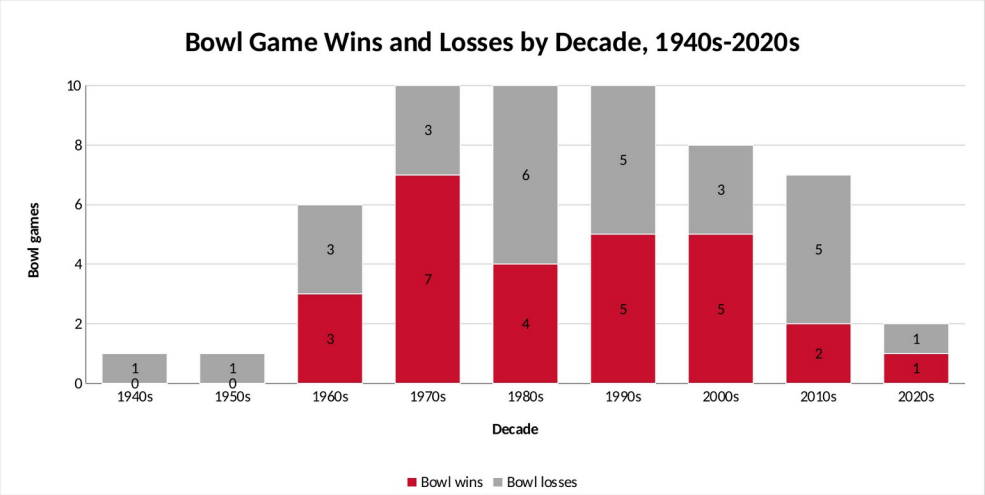


Story: Every bar gets shorter from the Big Eight to the Big 12 to the Big Ten. The biggest drop is rankings: 91% of Big Eight seasons ended ranked, but only 13% of Big Ten seasons did.

6.5 Goal 5: Bowl Games

Goal: Show bowl wins and losses by decade.

Chart: Stacked column chart (Excel).

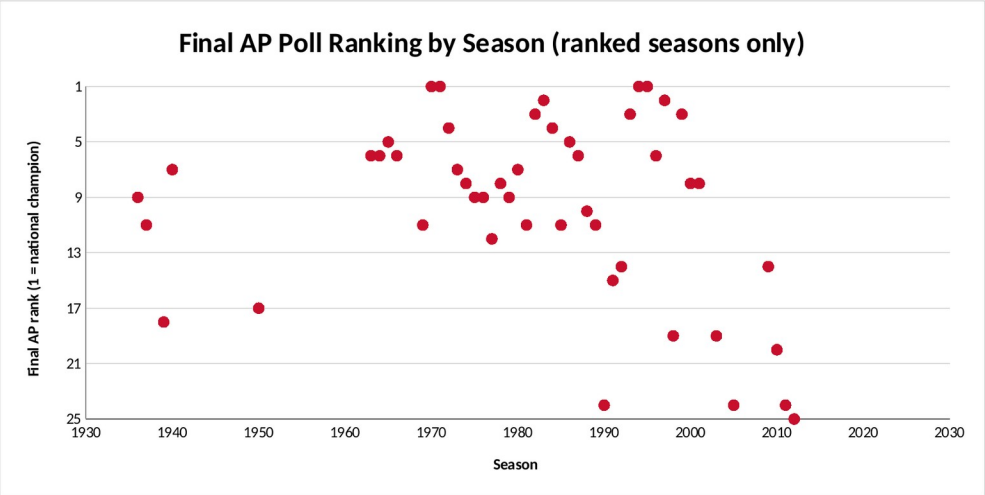


Story: Nebraska went to 35 bowl games in a row from 1969 to 2003. Their all-time bowl record is 27-28. They didn't make a bowl from 2017 to 2023.

6.6 Goal 6: Final AP Rankings

Goal: Show Nebraska's final AP ranking each season to see when they were a national power.

Chart: Scatter plot with #1 at the top (Excel).



Story: From 1969 to 2001 Nebraska was ranked every year and finished #1 four times. They haven't finished ranked since 2012.

Section 7. Conclusions

- Nebraska's best run was 1962 to 2001. They were ranked 33 years in a row and went to 35 bowl games in a row.
- Things started going downhill in the early 2000s, before Nebraska joined the Big Ten in 2011. The Big Ten years have been the worst (44.2% in conference games).
- Nebraska hasn't finished in the AP rankings since 2012.
- No coach since 2015 has a winning record.
- Going 7-6 with a bowl game in both 2024 and 2025 shows things might be getting better.

Next, it would be good to add recruiting rankings to see if they explain the drop.